political leaders, including the Minister of Communication and Information Technology A. Raja, as well as corporate honchos and well-known journalists. The conversations were interpreted to be about the 2G spectrum allocation by the Union government in 2008 to mobile network providers including Tata Teleservices.

The interception was approved by the Ministry of Home Affairs and was conducted with the avowed intention of uncovering money laundering, tax evasion and restricted financial practices. But the information that was collected ostensibly for an official investigation found its way into the public domain. In November 2010, a magazine published some transcripts of the conversations that the Income Tax Department had taped. Two days later, another magazine also published transcripts of some of the conversations and released audio files on its website. The needle of suspicion for leaking these pointed to some mobile network operators.

The leaked conversations revealed several alleged instances of corporates influencing political and commercial decisions of the government. But many were purely social in nature and contained nothing that involved any illegality. However, vested interests exploited even the most innocuous of these, among which were some conversations between Ratan and Radia.

Those involving Ratan had nothing that could legitimately damage the Tata Group's reputation for ethical behaviour. Yet, they tarnished both the group's and Ratan's images in the eyes of the public, as some of the reports were sensationalized to convey falsely that the conversations dealt with illegal activities. Some sections of the media may have been motivated by the intention of grabbing more readership, but the means they had chosen to achieve this was both violative of the legal rights of individuals and unethical.

The leaked content raised a host of ethical and legal questions. Did the government have the right to tap private conversations? Was there arbitrariness in the official decision-making regarding the 2G spectrum allocation? Why didn't the official agency intercepting the phone calls in the name of public interest keep them confidential?

The public narrative gradually shifted from possible illegalities in governmental decision-making to laboured conclusions drawn from social conversations. In the process, the all-important distinction between public interest and the right to privacy was lost, and all conversations were painted as attempts to manipulate government decisions.